attrition and patience. That memorable contest against Allan Donald typefies what Test cricket is all about for me, making it the pinnacle of all formats of the sport. Here was a fast bowler propelling the ball at close to 150 kph. For a batsman there's nothing more challenging than really hostile fast bowling in bowler-friendly conditions. You don't get to play spells like that in domestic cricket and surviving is a true test of a batsman's calibre.

At Johannesburg, I finally got to my hundred after lunch, facing 270 balls in the innings, which lasted for six and a half hours. With Kumble taking six wickets in South Africa's second innings, we managed to draw the match and went into the third Test at Port Elizabeth with all to play for. The other bowler who bowled very well for South Africa was Craig Matthews. He was the most accurate of the lot and bowled a crafty line outside off stump, from where the ball would generally swing away. Occasionally he would get one to nip back and it was difficult to play this incoming ball. So much so that almost the whole team ended up with very similar black bruises on our thighs after being hit by Matthews. We even joked about it in the dressing room, saying, '*Aare isko bhi medal mila hai dekh!*' (He too has got a medal. Check!)

Unfortunately, we lost the third Test at Port Elizabeth to the pace and guile of Allan Donald, who picked up twelve wickets in the match. We were still in the game at the end of the first innings of both teams, but it was Donald's opening burst in the second innings that made all the difference. We lost our first six wickets for 31 and, despite a brilliant hundred from Kapil Dev, we never really had a chance. I got a bad umpiring call and was declared out to Brett Schultz, caught behind, when the ball had actually hit the inside of my thigh. The umpire met me at the end of the game and apologized for getting it wrong. It was understandable, for umpiring is one of the most difficult jobs in cricket and it is only human to get things wrong sometimes.

We were determined to level the series in the fourth and final Test match at Cape Town, which started on 2 January 1993. While we failed to achieve that, we didn't play badly. Javagal Srinath bowled particularly impressively, picking up six wickets. This time Allan Donald bowled a lot of overs to me from round the wicket, pitching it short of a length to make the most of the spongy bounce Cape Town is known for. I decided to try a new approach. He was bowling short and was getting the balls to come into my body. I realized that the best way to counter him would be